In the meantime, Ratan also got ready to leave for the Taj. Just then, he got a call from Krishna Kumar informing him about the scale of the attack. Ratan reached the Taj around 10.45 p.m. When he arrived, there was absolute commotion with terrorists wielding automatic guns and grenades running amok. He too tried making his way into the hotel, but the police, who had arrived by then, prevented him. If anything happened to him, or if he were taken hostage, it would have been the biggest victory for the terrorists.

Ratan spent half the night watching and waiting outside on the footpath, pacing between the hotel and the adjoining Gateway of India. Krishna Kumar—who was constantly on the phone with Mahavir Singh Rathore, the chief of security of the Taj Group of Hotels, to know about the latest developments—was with Ratan. Ratan stood on the road looking up in horror, with 'tears in his eyes' as flames engulfed the more-than-a-century-old landmark. He was horrified and told himself, 'I cannot believe the hotel is burning down. It is just not possible.'

Recalling that night, Krishna Kumar said in an interview: 'It was a very sad moment for him … for all of us in the group at the senior leadership level, we had a passion for the Taj … So when that was attacked viciously on 26/11, I think like [mine] his heart broke too … the agony that he felt standing there three days … to see this virtually a temple [sic] go up in flames, in senseless violence, was a revolting sight … our hearts were broken, we had tears in our eyes.'

In an interview to Fareed Zakaria of CNN after the three-day-siege ended, Ratan remembered that he was 'truly emotionally overcome' by the sight of the 'old, venerable, rather beautiful building going up in flames'. The realization that there were several hundreds of people inside desperately waiting to be evacuated caused him extreme anxiety. He could hear the sound of exploding grenades and gunshots from inside the hotel, and felt 'tremendously helpless'. It was, as he said in 2015 when being conferred an award, a 'life-changing moment' that left a deep impact on him. For six months, his 'voice was breaking' and he 'could not speak clearly'.

For Ratan, just like the Tatas before him who were known for their fierce patriotism, it was not just an attack on a hotel belonging to his group, but on the nation.